Pay-Per-Move vs. Marketing Agencies: Why Moving Companies Are Switching

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The moving industry is littered with operators who spent thousands on marketing agencies and lead platforms and got back a fraction of what they paid. The math finally broke enough operators that an alternative emerged — and it's changing how independent moving companies think about customer acquisition.

The Problem With How Moving Companies Have Always Marketed

The agency model: You pay $1,500 to $3,000/month for someone to manage your Google Ads, maybe run some Facebook campaigns, build landing pages. They send you reports. Sometimes the phone rings more than usual. Sometimes it doesn't.

The problem: you're paying for activity, not results. A campaign that generates 200 clicks but zero booked jobs still costs you the monthly retainer. The agency's incentive is to keep you as a client, not to deliver a specific number of moves.

The lead platform model: You sign up for HireAHelper, Moving.com, moveBuddha, or similar platforms. You pay per lead — typically $25 to $80 each for shared leads. Multiple moving companies receive the same contact simultaneously. The customer gets called by 4 different movers in the next 10 minutes and books the first responsive one or the cheapest quote.

One operator described it clearly: "I was paying $60 for a lead and closing maybe 1 in 8. That's $480 in lead cost for a $700 move. I was making nothing."

The Real Math on Lead Platform Economics in 2026

Lead platform pricing has increased significantly. Current benchmarks:

Platform Type	Cost Per Lead 2026	Close Rate	Cost Per Acquired Job
Shared lead platforms	$35 – $80	10 – 18%	$195 – $800
Premium/exclusive leads	$80 – $180	25 – 35%	$230 – $720
Google Ads (self-managed)	$12 – $45/click	8 – 15% CVR	$80 – $560

At the high end of shared leads, you're spending $800 to acquire a job that might generate $900 in revenue. After labor, truck costs, supplies, and overhead, you're running at a loss.

Even at the low end — $195 per acquired job on a $600 average — that's a 32.5% marketing cost before a single mover is paid.

What Pay-Per-Move Changes

The pay-per-move model is conceptually simple: you pay a success fee only when a move is completed.

No lead fees. No monthly retainers. No paying for customers who get a quote and book someone else. If the job doesn't happen, you pay nothing.

The economics at 10 to 15% success fee:

- Average job: $800
- Success fee: $80 to $120
- Marketing cost as % of revenue: 10 to 15%

Compare that to shared lead platforms where marketing cost runs 20 to 50%+ of job revenue. Or agencies where you're paying $2,000/month regardless of job volume.

The psychological shift is just as important as the math. When you're on a retainer, every slow week feels like money burning. You're writing a check whether the phone rings or not. On pay-per-move, a slow week costs you nothing in marketing. The risk stays with the acquisition partner, not with you.

"But Isn't It Just Like a Broker?"

This question comes up. The answer is no — and the difference matters.

A broker aggregates moving demand and parcels it out to available carriers. They often compete on price, commoditize your service, and retain the customer relationship. You're a vendor to them.

A pay-per-move growth partner's revenue depends on your success. They're incentivized to send you high-quality customers who book, show up, and complete the move — because that's when they get paid. The business model aligns incentives in a way that brokerage doesn't.

What Doesn't Change With Pay-Per-Move

Your operations have to be solid. Pay-per-move doesn't fix:

- Crews that show up late or damage furniture
- Owners who don't answer calls or follow up on inquiries
- Pricing that's not competitive for your market

The model delivers opportunities. Converting those opportunities into completed, satisfied moves is still your job.

Want to see what pay-per-move looks like for your market? Book a free strategy call and we'll show you what volume is realistic and what the economics look like against what you're currently spending.